

■ By Damayanti Datta

Hello?" A young female voice husks hesitantly. "My boyfriend wants me to act out a part from a porno flick. Should I?" Red lights flicker on the broadcasting console as Anil Srivatsa comes up with a cheery repartee. It's shortly after 10 p.m. On this particular night, sitting in his cosy, moodily-lit studio and surrounded by the detritus of a busy Wednesday, he has invited his listeners to share their thoughts on sexual fantasies. Another caller blips in. Then another. For the next three hours, he gets snowed under. It's not just today. Twice a week, for the last one year, Srivatsa—talk show host and chief operating officer of Meow 104.8 FM—has been putting on his headphones to tackle sex and relationships on his late-night chat show, *Meow Between the Sheets*. And they discuss it all, from foreplay, sexual fantasies, one-night stands, affairs, abortion, HIV to sexual abuse. It's not just Delhi. The response is the same wherever the channel is setting its footprint—Mumbai, Kolkata, Patiala, Amritsar or Jodhpur.

The nation is talking and worrying about its sex life with a new nervous intensity. In a country that doesn't even recognise sexual incompatibility as a ground for divorce, sex has not only become a preoccupation but the cornerstone for a new kind of discourse. We listen to "*Choli ke piche*", giggle over wardrobe malfunctions of fashionistas, surf through late night television's agony aunt sex talks, gossip about the dirty secrets of celebrities, lap up (and then condemn) the media for covering sex crimes, log on to the Internet to engage in intimate conversations with strangers and bathe in all that warm cyberswill. The word "sex" is no longer a taboo, as we shed our prudish pasts and embrace a new era of openness.

Yet, underneath all this, there's an astonishingly varied banquet of half-baked theories and ignorance. Ask Dr Bir Singh, professor of community medicine at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIMS). His desk is piled high with files containing innumerable e-mail printouts from across the country and constantly-ringing helplines. "We come across an

astounding level of sexual disharmony, ignorance and myths about the human body and sex among young people," he says. To rise to the occasion, Singh and his team at AIMS have just floated the first-of-its-kind initiative: "Pre-marriage Training Course For A Happy Married Life".

Surveys confirm that young Indians do not know enough about what goes on between the sheets. Talking About Reproductive and Sexual Health Issues (TARSHI), which runs a helpline, received over 59,000 calls last year from soon-to-be married men. Over 70 per cent of the callers, below age 30, sought information on women's anatomy, the 'suhag raat', what would happen if they fail to perform on the first night and how to make their wives sexually fulfilled. In 2005, a Kamasutra sex survey reported that most acquire their knowledge about sex through "self-reading", "friends", "blue films" or the

LET'S TALK

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brutal mechanics of Internet porn. According to the 2008 Google Trends report, India tops the global charts of people searching up "sex" online.

A helpline on Singh's table rings, but there's silence when he picks up. "That's very common," he smiles. "They want to talk about their problems, dial our numbers, then suddenly get cold feet." Who are "they"? The AIMS clinic doesn't solicit personal information, but going by the tonnes of e-mails it has received since 2002, "they" are mostly male, from

across India—big cities and smaller towns. The class background can be guessed from the fact that they have e-mail access and write in English. They are also largely young, going by the rampant use of "sms-English".

Their most common queries are on sexual "normalness"—anxiety about the body and the oft-repeated question, "Am I normal?"—on the anatomy of the opposite sex and on variations of making love. Sometimes the level of unawareness is so high that Singh is taken by surprise. He mentions a man,

